

Folk Models of Good and Bad Taste: A Computational Text Analysis

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July 18, 2026

Abstract

Indifferent Sociologists have long debated the nature of “good” and “bad” taste, yet how lay individuals actually define these categories remains under-explored. Using open-ended survey responses, this research note applies BERTopic to inductively map folk cultural models of taste definitions. I identify distinct cultural models for “good taste” (e.g., Subjectivity, Aesthetics, Style) and “bad taste” (e.g., Dislike, Poor Choices, Poor Manners). Chi-square cross-tabulations reveal that these cultural models form internally coherent cultural logics across both positive and negative evaluations. Furthermore, heatmaps mapping these cultural models onto 19 specific cultural domains reveal that while core domains like Music and Clothing are universally subjected to taste distinctions, moralized cultural models are associated with a heightened propensity to draw taste boundaries across nearly all domains.

1 Introduction

The sociological study of cultural stratification has traditionally focused on how cultural consumption patterns map onto social hierarchies (Bourdieu, 1984). However, theoretical conceptualizations of “good” and “bad” taste are rarely compared against how everyday people implicitly define these constructs, although some recent interview-based work has begun to plumb this subject (Haak and Wilterdink, 2019; Jarness and Friedman, 2017). Do people view good taste as an aesthetic achievement, a moral disposition, or mere consensus with dominant trends? Better understanding these folk models of taste can provide vital insight into the contemporary boundaries of cultural inclusion and exclusion.

2 Research Questions

This research note is guided by three primary research questions:

1. What are the distinct, latent cultural models that lay individuals use to define “good taste” and “bad taste”?
2. How do cultural models of good taste relate to cultural models of bad taste? Are they structurally coupled into broader cultural logics?
3. How do these taste cultural models map onto specific cultural domains (e.g., beer, classical music, wrestling)?

3 Methods

To analyze these short, unstructured participant-level text responses (hereafter “documents”), I used **BERTopic**. During preprocessing, domain-specific survey artifacts (e.g., “good,” “bad,” “taste,” “don’t”) were removed from each document because these words—mostly paraphrasing the original question—were overwhelmingly common across documents and thus did little to differentiate them. We also remove common English stop words from each document (e.g., the, it, is, do, etc.). The algorithm was optimized for each of the two text fields independently to prevent vocabulary blurring. Finally, cross-tabulations and domain-distinction Likert scale heatmaps were generated to examine the coherence of these classifications.

3.1 Parameter Selection and Model Robustness

To ensure our topic solutions were empirically robust, we evaluated BERTopic models across a range of `min_topic_size` parameters (5, 10, 15, and 20). The optimal configuration balances two competing demands: maximizing the granularity of semantic clusters (number of distinct topics) while minimizing the number of documents relegated to the outlier bin (Topic -1). As shown in Figure 1, the 3-topic solution for Good Taste (at size 10) and the 8-topic solution for Bad Taste (at size 5) proved optimal. For Good Taste, requiring larger

topic sizes rapidly collapses the model into two generic topics, whereas for Bad Taste, forcing a minimum size of 10 collapses 8 distinct schemas into a binary, stripping away important qualitative variation.

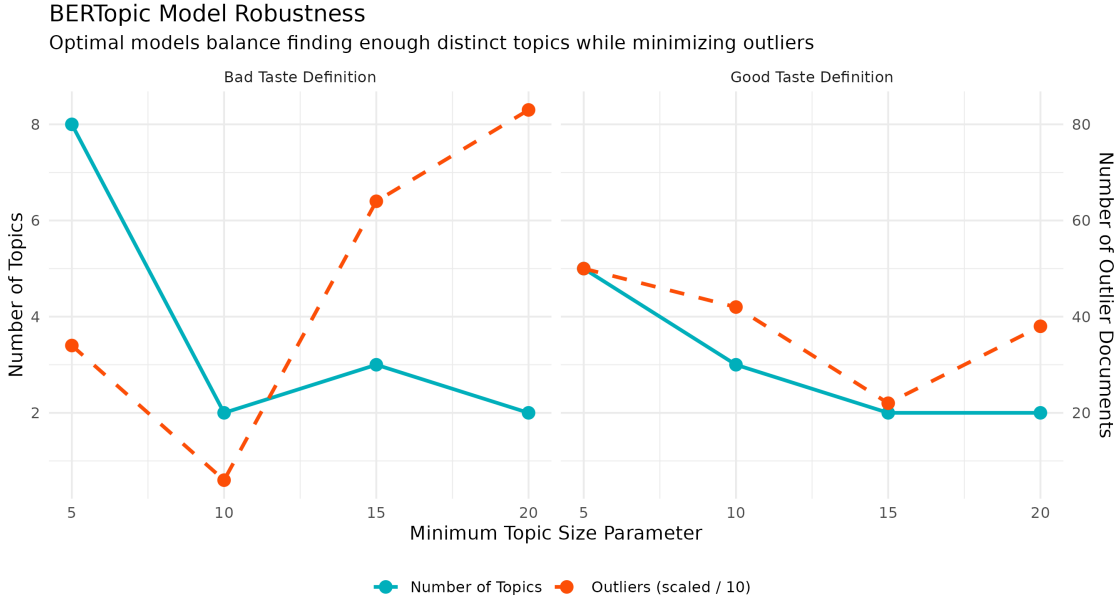


Figure 1: BERTopic Parameter Robustness: Trade-off between Number of Topics and Outlier Documents across `min_topic_size`

4 Results

4.1 Cultural Models of Taste

Topic	Count	Name	Representation
0	108	Taste Good Like Person	taste, good, like, person, things, think, people, say, me...
1	58	Like Things Choices Art	like, things, choices, art, shows, good, appreciate, appe...
2	16	Means Like Good People	means, like, good, people, interact, services, style, loo...

Table 1: Good Taste Def Summary

For **Bad Taste**, respondents defined it through eight distinct cultural models, including *Dislike/Subjective*, *Poor Choices*, *Tacky/Loud*, *Low-Brow Media*, *Ugly Style*, *Low Quality*, *Immoral Art*, and *Poor Manners*.

4.2 Cross-Cultural Model Logics

To test whether these cultural models are isolated or form coherent “logics,” I cross-tabulated respondents’ primary cultural models across the two questions. The associations are highly

Topic	Name	Representative Document
0	Taste Good Like Person	“If someone has a good taste, then they like things that many people view are ”good”. It’s a very subjective thing to have a ”good taste”, I think it depends on how you grew up. In certain areas, it’d be luxury things or elegant things that are defined as good taste. In other parts, it could just be like something that isn’t as ”Trendy” as what most people like. I’d also say that people with ”good taste”, tend to think on their own and don’t follow what others like.”
1	Like Things Choices Art	“I would like to acknowledge that there are shows that I watch that are not ’art.’ However, I recognize that they are not art. The shows that do transcend the medium and are critically and artistically acknowledged, are considered ’good taste.’ Those who enjoy these shows are showing they have good taste.”
2	Means Like Good People	“It means that they know what is good, in style, good quality, has an eye for art or design and knows the difference between expensive and quality items.”

Table 2: Representative Quotes for Good Taste Cultural Models

Topic	Count	Name	Representation
0	61	Bad Taste Things Person	bad, taste, things, person, means, think, people, say, go...
1	53	Like Things Choices Just	like, things, choices, just, think, care, maybe, good, ga...
2	19	Person Loud Sense Colors	person, loud, sense, colors, boo, bold, drama, character,...
3	15	Music Movies Enjoy Shows	music, movies, enjoy, shows, bad, watch, taste, say, medi...
4	14	Colors Look Bad Ugly	colors, look, bad, ugly, clothing, taste, color, style, p...
5	11	Means Usually Like Quality	means, usually, like, quality, acceptable, racist, horrib...
6	9	Art Opinions Immoral Value	art, opinions, immoral, value, kitsch, artists, behaving,...
7	8	Poor Violence Manner Humor	poor, violence, manner, humor, action, disrespectful, amu...

Table 3: Bad Taste Def Summary

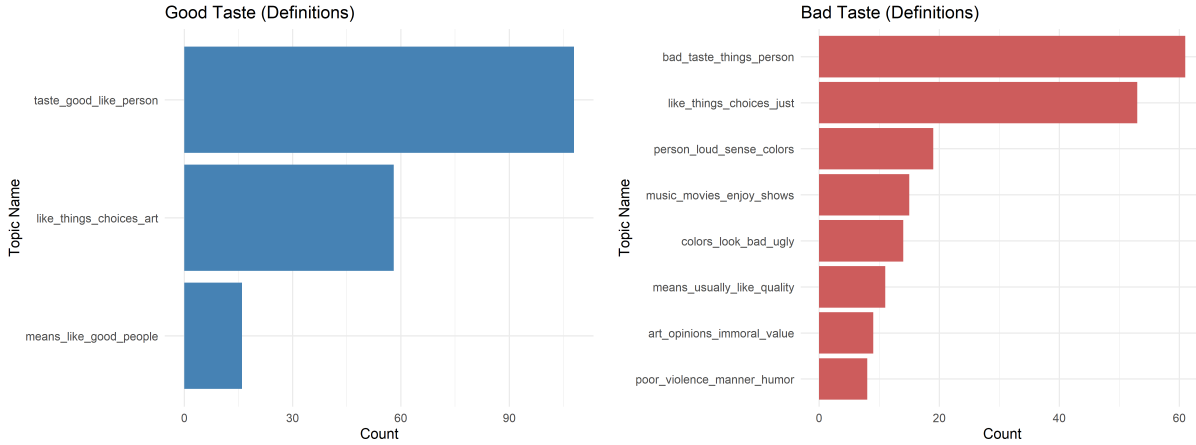


Figure 2: Topic Frequencies for Good and Bad Taste (Definitions)

Topic	Name	Representative Document
0	Bad Taste Things Person	“Someone who has bad taste in my opinion would mean that my opinions of those tastes are bad. To put simply, the tastes that I dislike would make me think a person who likes them has bad taste.”
1	Like Things Choices Just	“some just like anything really don’t care”
2	Person Loud Sense Colors	“I think of someone who is loud common uncouth tacky or crass. I think of tacky attire and loud colors not bold but loud colors.”
3	Music Movies Enjoy Shows	“Someone has a bad taste in something when they enjoy something I do not; for example I would say someone might have a ‘bad taste’ in movies if they watch a lot of rom-coms. Someone else could also say that they have a good taste in movies; it is very subjective.”
4	Colors Look Bad Ugly	“A person who has a bad taste is a person who likes ugly and cheap stuff. He/she likes to collect junk or dress ugly. For example, he wears jean and t-shirt to a wedding. Another example, she collects junk jewelry like fake ugly bracelet.”
5	Means Usually Like Quality	“It means that I do not like said thing or that I can not see why a person would like it. I would also say something is in bad taste due to its content like if it was racist, sexist, homophobic, etc.”
6	Art Opinions Immoral Value	“Any art promote instant gratifications, selfish, negative and destructive thinking or behaving.”
7	Poor Violence Manner Humor	“Generally they are rude, vulgar and like things that are insulting to others. If they wear a shirt that says ‘I’m with stupid’ or has foul language I would say they have bad taste.”

Table 4: Representative Quotes for Bad Taste Cultural Models

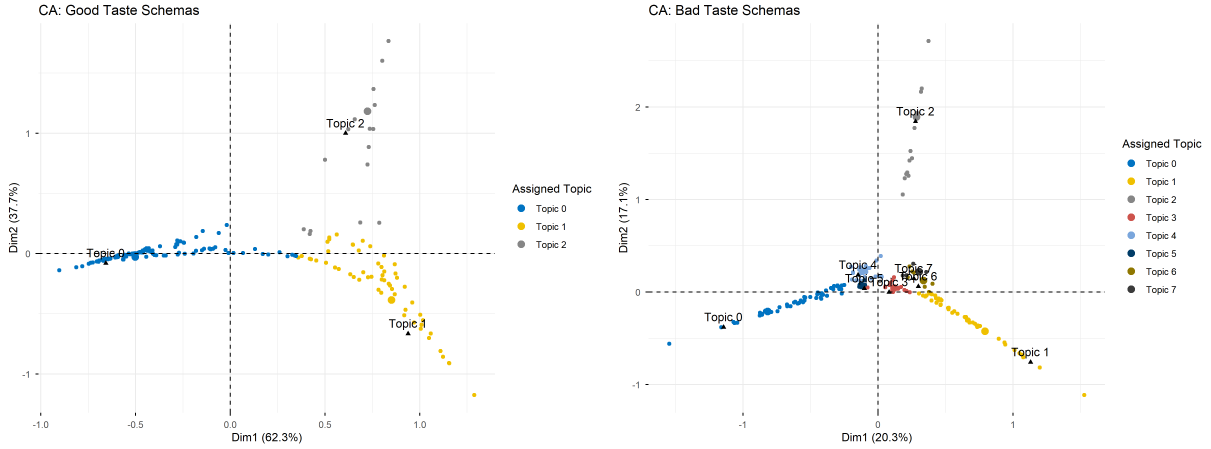
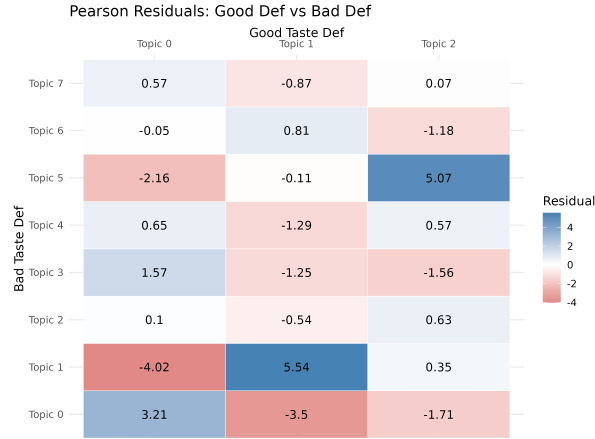


Figure 3: Correspondence Analysis of Taste Cultural Models (Definitions)

significant. For instance, a respondent’s definition of Good Taste strongly predicts their definition of Bad Taste ($\chi^2 = 115.52, p < 0.001$). Individuals who define good taste as subjective similarity overwhelmingly define bad taste simply as subjective dislike.



4.3 Demographics

To examine whether taste cultural models are patterned by socio-demographic factors, I fit multinomial logistic regression models predicting respondents’ primary topic cultural model (across both models) using their Age, Gender, Education, and Political Orientation. The Wald χ^2 tests are presented below.

Model	Predictor	Wald χ^2	Df	<i>p</i> -value
Good Taste Def	Age	3.84	2	0.1464
Good Taste Def	Gender	0.53	2	0.7669
Good Taste Def	EducationLevel_Coded	0.94	2	0.6253
Good Taste Def	Political	2.51	2	0.2847
Bad Taste Def	Age	12.88	7	0.0750
Bad Taste Def	Gender	2.34	7	0.9384
Bad Taste Def	EducationLevel_Coded	4.68	7	0.6991
Bad Taste Def	Political	7.31	7	0.3972

Table 5: Multinomial Logistic Regression Wald Tests for Topic Predictors

4.4 Domain Distinction PCA and ANOVA

To analyze respondents’ propensity to draw cultural boundaries across domains without testing 19 individual domains simultaneously, I conducted a Principal Component Analy-

sis (PCA) on the distinction ratings. I ran this for four different blocks of survey items: *Distinction 1*, *Distinction 2*, *Importance*, and *Knowledge*.

The first dimension captures a general propensity to draw distinctions across all domains (as all variables load positively). The subsequent dimensions capture domain-specific clusters (e.g., separating traditional high-brow arts from pop culture or recreational activities).

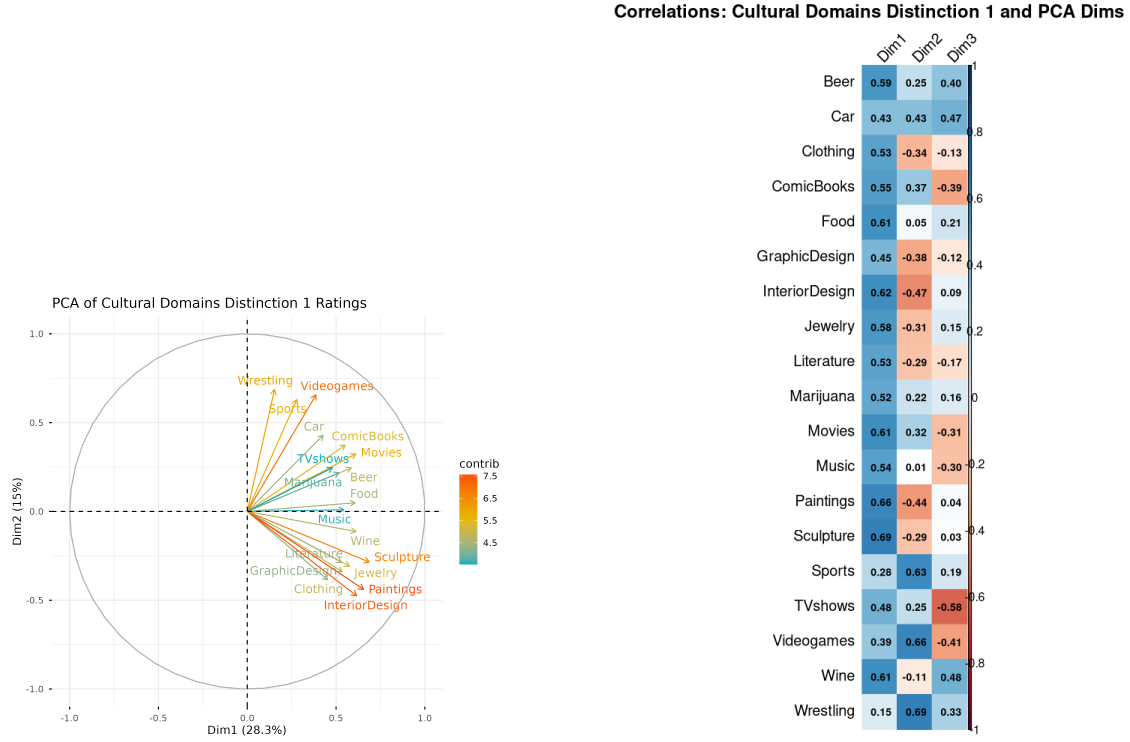


Figure 4: PCA and Correlations for Distinction 1

I extracted the individual respondent scores for the first three PCA dimensions for each block and ran a MANOVA (Pillai’s trace) to test whether mean scores across the three dimensions differ significantly depending on the respondent’s topic cultural model assignment. The results demonstrate how different cultural models of taste correspond to distinct configurations of cultural boundary-drawing.

Predictor	Pillai’s Trace	approx F	num Df	den Df	p -value
Good Taste Def	0.043	1.50	6	406	0.175
Bad Taste Def	0.123	1.22	21	597	0.228

* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$

Table 6: MANOVA Results: Differences in PCA Dimensions (1-3) of Cultural Domains Distinction 1 Ratings by Taste Cultural Model.

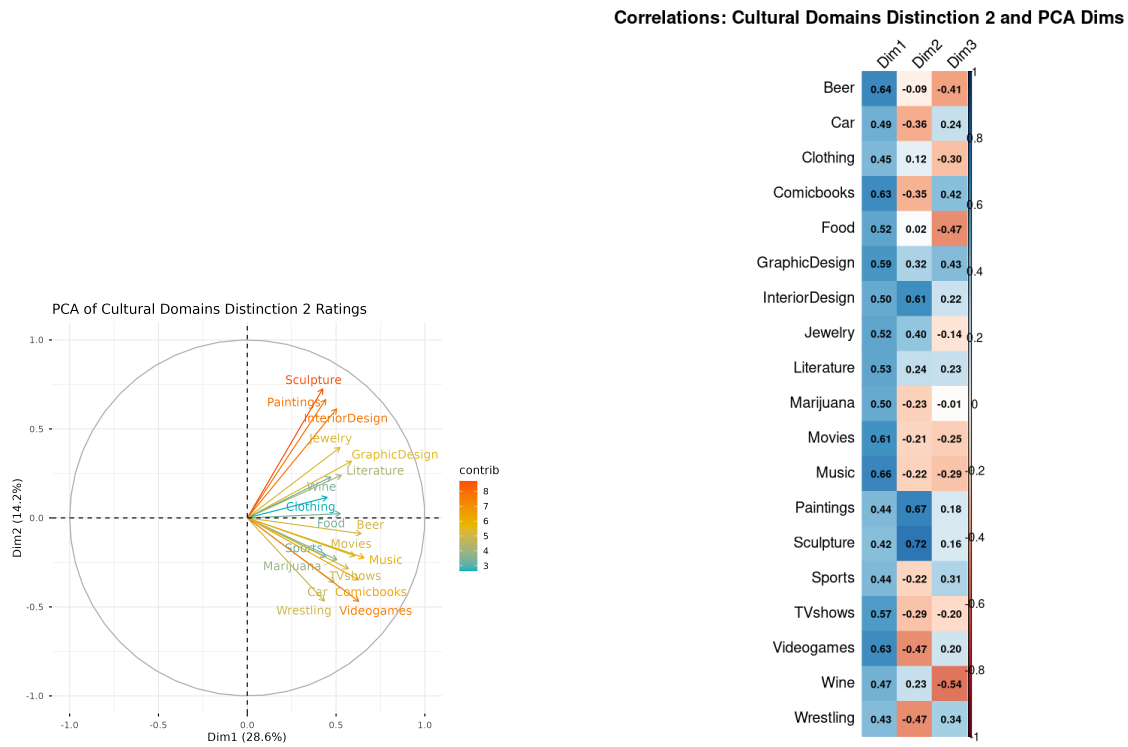


Figure 5: PCA and Correlations for Distinction 2

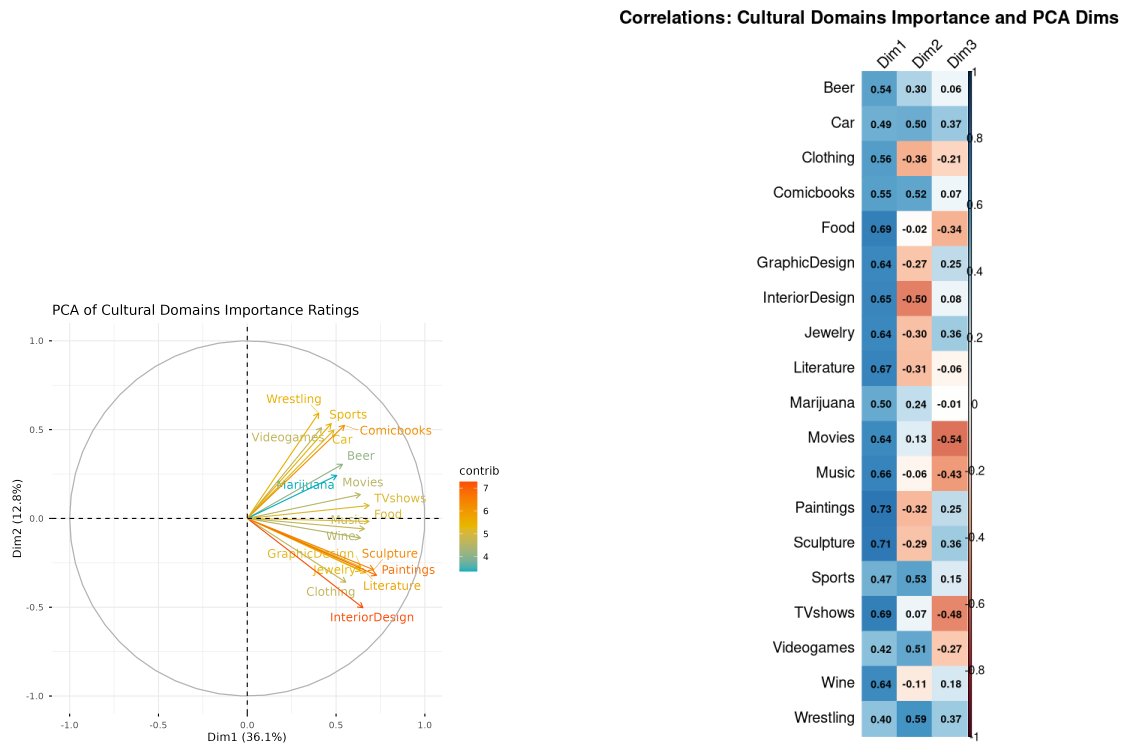


Figure 6: PCA and Correlations for Importance

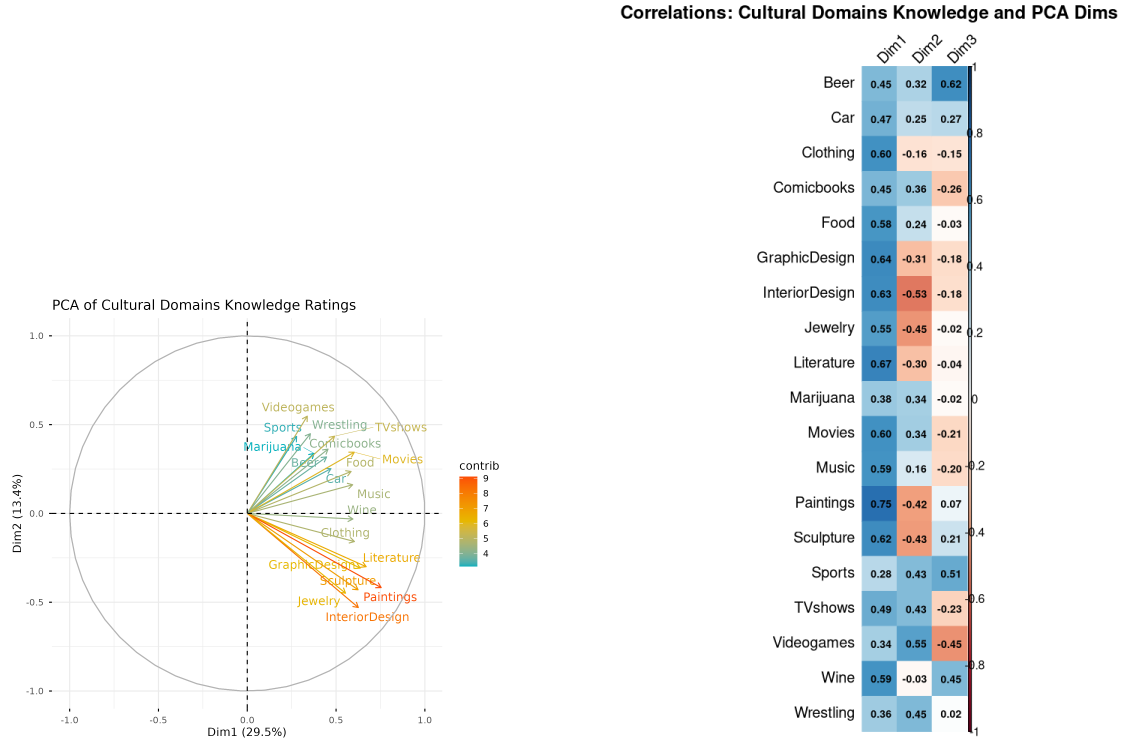


Figure 7: PCA and Correlations for Knowledge

Predictor	Pillai's Trace	approx F	num Df	den Df	p -value
Good Taste Def	0.018	0.62	6	406	0.718
Bad Taste Def	0.098	0.96	21	597	0.506

* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$

Table 7: MANOVA Results: Differences in PCA Dimensions (1-3) of Cultural Domains Distinction 2 Ratings by Taste Cultural Model.

Predictor	Pillai's Trace	approx F	num Df	den Df	p -value
Good Taste Def	0.039	1.35	6	406	0.233
Bad Taste Def	0.125	1.24	21	597	0.214

* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$

Table 8: MANOVA Results: Differences in PCA Dimensions (1-3) of Cultural Domains Importance Ratings by Taste Cultural Model.

Predictor	Pillai's Trace	approx F	num Df	den Df	p -value
Good Taste Def	0.026	0.90	6	406	0.495
Bad Taste Def	0.089	0.86	21	597	0.638

* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$

Table 9: MANOVA Results: Differences in PCA Dimensions (1-3) of Cultural Domains Knowledge Ratings by Taste Cultural Model.

4.5 Domain Distinction Heatmaps

Respondents were also asked to rate whether it “makes sense” to distinguish good and bad taste across 19 different domains (from -3 = Strongly Disagree to +3 = Strongly Agree).

Visualizing these scores as heatmaps across our topic clusters reveals several structural universals: regardless of the cultural model, respondents highly agree that taste distinctions make sense for **Clothing, Interior Design, Movies, Music, and Paintings**, while rejecting taste distinctions for **Car Races and Wrestling**.

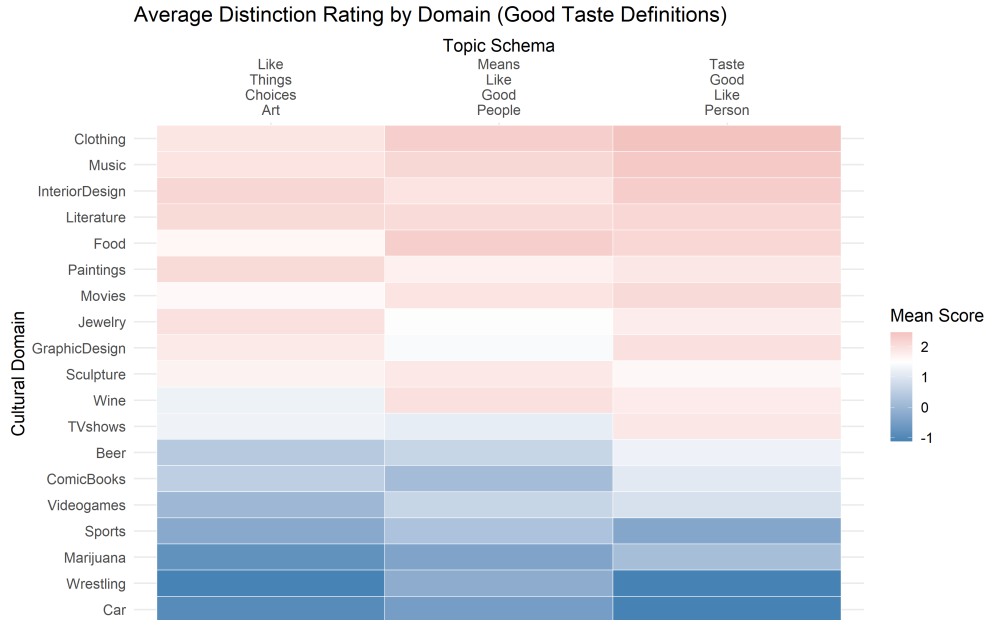


Figure 8: Average Distinction Rating by Domain and Good Taste Cultural Model (Definitions)

5 Discussion

This text-analytic exploration demonstrates that lay definitions of taste are not monolithic; they are multi-dimensional, spanning aesthetic, homophilous, and moral dimensions. Crucially, these dimensions are symmetrical. If an individual views good taste through the lens of objective aesthetic criteria, they evaluate bad taste using the exact same yardstick.

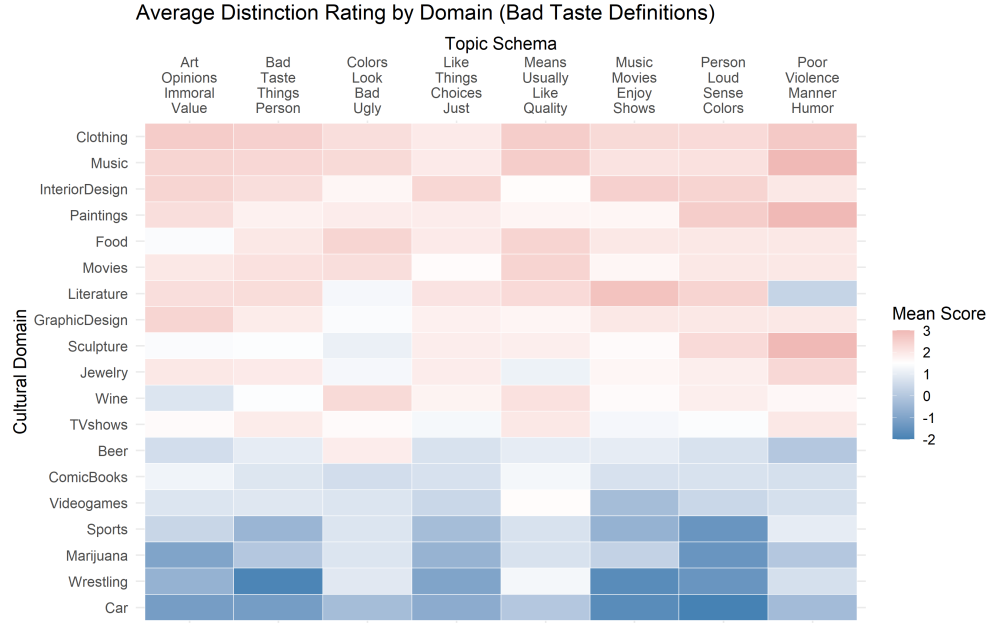


Figure 9: Average Distinction Rating by Domain and Bad Taste Cultural Model (Definitions)

Furthermore, by mapping these inductively derived cultural models back onto structured survey variables, we observe that the specific folk model an individual uses dictates the breadth of their cultural boundary-drawing. Future research should expand on these findings by examining how these deeply held, qualitative cultural models of taste interact with actual patterns of structural inequality.

References

- Bourdieu, P. (1984). *Distinction: A Social Critique of the Judgement of Taste*. Harvard University Press, Cambridge, MA.
- Haak, M. v. d. and Wilterdink, N. (2019). Struggling with distinction: How and why people switch between cultural hierarchy and equality. *European Journal of Cultural Studies*, 22(4):416–432.
- Jarness, V. and Friedman, S. (2017). ‘i’m not a snob, but...’: Class boundaries and the downplaying of difference. *Poetics*, 61:14–25.